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Is Mobility of Data a Special Problem for Qualitative Research?

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University of Essex JISC E·S·R·C ECONOMIC & SOCIAL RESEARCH COUNCIL

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Presentation Outline

Working definition of data mobility for qualitative archiving

Researcher assumptions

Data archiving lifecycle (for text, audio and video data)

- ingest / acquisition
- preservation / processing
- dissemination / usage

User expectations

Closing remarks

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Defining Data Mobility

UKDA archival procedures are based on

- making data available to as wide an audience as possible
- responding to the way data is produced and used in a changing environment

Key aspects of data mobility

- data is easily accessible
- open to use across disciplines
- open to combining / modelling data in new ways

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Researcher Assumptions

Experience of attempting to acquire material (in some cases) shows:

- mobility of data means many researchers anti archiving and sharing
- fearful confidentiality will be breached
- online access = uncontrolled access

Not confined to academia

- real world reporting of data loss stresses dangers
- fuelling of general unease about data accumulation

Concerns about the mobility of qualitative data immobilises it

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Solutions

But there are solutions to these problems

- contribute to wider societal concerns
- promote archiving at level of individual researchers and research programmes

Successful liaison is currently allowing deposits of data from e.g.

- Rural Environment and Land Use Programme (RELU)
- http://www.data-archive.ac.uk/relu/
- highly diverse data types
- highly diverse content

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Ingest

The UKDA routinely acquires qualitative data for its collections based upon

- standardised procedures at ingest **combined** with discussions with potential depositors
- promotion of user registration and standard confidentiality agreements
- promotion of bespoke access restrictions
- clarification of consent and ethical and legal foundations of projects

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MANAGE AND SHARE DATA

ABOUT UKDA ▶

MANAGE AND SHARE DATA
Sharing data - why and how?
Consent, confidentiality and ethics
Copyright
Data documentation and metadata
Data formats and software
Data storage, back-up, and security
FAQ
Advice and training

DATA ▶

SUPPORT ▶

RESEARCH AND DEVELOPMENT ▶

NEWS ▶

Data created from research are valuable resources that can be used and re-used for future scientific and educational purposes. Sharing data facilitates research often beyond the scope of the original research, encourages scientific inquiry, avoids duplicate data collection and provides resources for education and training. UKDA has years of expertise in implementing and training in best practices in data management and methods of data sharing.

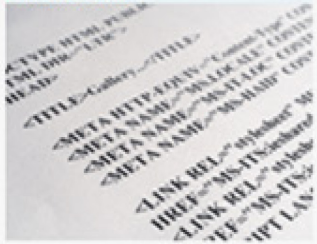
It is a reality that most research data can be shared with other researchers. This suite of web pages aims to provide data creators, data managers and data curators with best practice strategies and methods for creating, preparing and storing shareable datasets. Advice has been divided into a number of key areas or modules providing detailed information on each topic.

Sharing data - why and how? ▶

Consent, confidentiality and ethics ▶

Copyright ▶

Data documentation and metadata ▶



Data formats and software ▶

Data storage, back-up, and security ▶

SEARCH

GO

all UKDA web site
Data Catalogue

UKDA SERVICES ▼

Managing and Sharing Data
a best practice guide for researchers

Printed copies of the brochure are available on request from publicity enquiries.

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Case Study

A case study:

SN 5407 - Health and Social Consequences of the Foot and Mouth Disease Epidemic in North Cumbria, 2001-2003

- highly sensitive data – text, audio and images
- contacted about archiving early in the research process
- advised on limited transcript anonymisation
- standard confidentiality safeguards for text material
- conditional access for audio

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Acquiring Qualitative Data

Experience of archiving sensitive data in this case shows:

- mobility of digital data is not a bar to archiving and sharing
- confidentiality can be protected as part of formal archiving

Archiving material with clear boundaries of use

- liberates immobilised data
- ensures confidentiality undertakings respected
- controlled access = secure online access

Preservation and Processing

Preservation and processing interacts with data mobility

- future proofing
- continued usabilty

Processing creates new metadata

- further increases data mobility
- provides points of entry to collections
- expands potential usage

All working to keep data accessible and increase its mobility

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Case Study

A case study:

SN 2000 – The Edwardians: Family Life and Work experience Before 1918

- life story collection
- 453 interviews transcribed
- Over 2500 individual audio recordings
- standard confidentiality safeguards for text and audio

Processing carried out in stages

- each attracting new users and types of usage
- some completely unanticipated

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Dissemination / Usage

Many of the benefits of mobility for qualitative data lie in delivery

- provision of original file formats
- enhancement of original material: pdf, rtf, xml, steaming audio etc
- ability to combine different data in new and novel ways
    - dataset guides
    - teaching and learning guides
    - thematic guides
    - technical guides

http://www.esds.ac.uk/support/onlineguides.asp

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User Expectations

Researchers in traditional archives accommodate limitations of less mobile data

- access is restricted to a single physical location
- accept restrictions on usage within the archive
- experience of digital archives are changing attitudes

User expectations of digital archives differ substantially

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User Expectations

Experience of ‘online’ access encourages expectations of

- instant access
- delivery by theme not collection
- resources tailored to the users specific needs

Need to recognise roots of this are in the mobility of digital media

Assess where some expectations can be met and used positively

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Final Thoughts

Success in archiving qualitative material rests on being responsive to attitudes to data mobility of depositors and users

Recognition of influence of data mobility on archiving qualitative data

Barriers to preserving and sharing data can be overcome

Not a special problem – a special consideration

Managing and Sharing Data – a best practice guide for researchers

http://www.data-archive.ac.uk/news/publications/managingsharing.pdf